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GST 102: Use of English II - Essays, Letters and Advanced Comprehension

Write the essays, letters and reports that university assessment actually rewards

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

GST 102 moves from sentence rules to whole pieces of writing. This pack gives you reusable structures for argumentative and expository essays, formal letters, reports and minutes, plus a marking-style checklist so you can grade your own drafts before your lecturer does.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Plan an argumentative or expository essay in five minutes using a clear thesis and paragraph outline.
- Write a formal letter, application letter and simple report with correct layout and register.
- Use cohesive devices without overusing 'moreover' and 'furthermore'.
- Edit your own draft for structure, grammar, punctuation and word choice.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The five-minute essay plan

Most weak essays fail at the planning stage. Five minutes of planning saves twenty minutes of confused writing.

1. Underline the instruction words: discuss, argue, compare, describe, evaluate. Each demands a different structure.
2. Write a one-sentence thesis: the exact position your essay will defend.
3. List three body points. Each must be different, relevant and supportable.
4. For each body point, note one example or piece of evidence.

5. Decide your conclusion in one sentence before you start writing.

> **The thesis test**
> If your thesis could be agreed with by everyone, it is too vague. 'Technology is useful' is not a thesis. 'Smartphones help freshers study only when notifications are controlled' is.

Paragraph architecture

A body paragraph should do one job: prove one point. The most reliable pattern is claim, explanation, evidence, link.

- Claim: a topic sentence that states the point directly.
- Explanation: why the claim is true in your context.
- Evidence: an example, statistic, experience or reference.
- Link: connect back to the thesis or forward to the next point.
- Keep paragraphs between four and eight sentences. Very long paragraphs hide your argument.

Argumentative versus expository essays

Both need structure, but they answer different questions.

- Argumentative: take a side, acknowledge the strongest opposing view, then rebut it. Do not sit on the fence unless the question asks you to.
- Expository: explain a process, concept or phenomenon clearly. Your job is clarity, not persuasion.
- Narrative: tell a story with a point. Avoid ending with 'and that was how I learnt a lesson' unless the lesson is specific.
- Compare and contrast: organise by criteria (cost, speed, reliability) rather than describing one item fully and then the other.

> **Counter-argument formula**
> Some students argue that X because Y. That view has merit, but it overlooks Z. When Z is considered, X becomes less convincing than it first appears.

Formal letters without embarrassment

Formal letters are marked on layout, tone and completeness as much as on grammar.

- Two addresses: your address, then the recipient's address, then the date.
- Salutation: 'Dear Sir/Madam' when the name is unknown; 'Dear Mr Okafor' when known.
- Subject line: short and specific, for example 'Application for the Position of Library Assistant'.
- Opening: state your purpose in the first two sentences. Do not begin with 'I am writing this letter to tell you that'.
- Body: one paragraph per issue. Be direct and courteous.
- Closing: 'Yours faithfully' after 'Dear Sir/Madam'; 'Yours sincerely' after a named recipient.

- Sign and print your full name.

Reports and minutes

A report answers a question for someone who was not there. Minutes record decisions, not conversations.

- Report structure: title, terms of reference, procedure, findings, conclusion, recommendations.
- Write findings as evidence, not opinion: 'Twenty of 30 students surveyed...' not 'Everybody knows...'.
- Minutes: date, time, venue, attendance, agenda items, decisions, action owners, next meeting.
- Record decisions and action points, not every contribution.
- Use past tense for what happened and present tense for standing rules.

Expository writing: explaining without wandering

Exposition answers a question the reader already has, in an order the reader can follow. The reliable structure is: define the thing, explain how it works, show why it matters, then deal with the difficulty a reader will raise. Each move is a paragraph or two, and the whole piece announces its shape in the first hundred words.

The most common weakness is unmotivated description. A student writes four paragraphs on the history of a topic before stating what the essay is about. Put the question in the first two sentences, then use history only where it explains the present.

Exposition also demands examples that are doing work. An example should be specific enough to be checked and typical enough to support the generalisation. "Many students struggle" is not evidence; "in the first semester, three of the four students I interviewed had never used a library catalogue" is.

Argument: claim, warrant, evidence, objection

An argument has four parts. The claim is what you want accepted. The warrant is the principle connecting evidence to claim. The evidence is what you can point to. The objection is the strongest reason a sensible person would disagree, which you must answer.

Students often supply evidence without a warrant, so the evidence sits there unexplained. "Enrolment rose by 12 per cent after the fee was reduced" is a fact; the argument needs: rising enrolment follows fee reduction because cost is a barrier for applicants, therefore reducing fees widens access - and then the objection: the rise may reflect population growth, so a comparison with neighbouring institutions is needed.

Weak arguments share a symptom: they cannot be disagreed with. If no evidence could count against your claim, you have stated a preference, not an argument.

> **Steel-man the objection**
> State the opposing case in its strongest form, then answer it. A weak objection is a way of avoiding the argument while appearing to have one.

Summary, paraphrase and citation

Summary compresses the whole of a source's argument, in your words, at a fraction of its length. Paraphrase restates a specific passage closely, also in your words. Quotation reproduces exact words in quotation marks. All three require a citation; none of them removes the need for your own comment.

Plagiarism is not only copying. It includes paraphrasing without citation, borrowing a structure without acknowledgement, and submitting work written by someone else. The defence is procedural: take notes with the page number at the moment of reading, keep a source list as you go, and write your first draft from your notes rather than from the open book.

Use quotation sparingly and always for a reason: because the wording itself is the point, because the author is an authority you are invoking, or because you intend to disagree precisely. A paragraph made of quotations is a collage, not an argument.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Building an argument paragraph from a fact

You have one statistic and need a paragraph that argues rather than reports.

1. State the claim: cheaper data plans have widened access to online learning.
2. State the warrant: access depends on cost, so price falls change participation.
3. Present the evidence and its source.
4. Acknowledge the objection: falling prices coincide with rising smartphone ownership.
5. Answer with a comparison or a control.
6. Conclude with the limited claim your evidence actually supports.

> **What to carry forward**
> A statistic is not an argument until a warrant connects it to a claim.

2. Summarising without plagiarising

A source runs to six hundred words. Produce a summary and a paraphrase of its key paragraph.

1. Read once for the argument, noting the main claim and the three supports.
2. Close the source and write the summary from memory in three sentences.
3. Open the source and check that nothing essential is missing and no wording is copied.
4. For the paraphrase, change the sentence structure entirely, not just the synonyms.
5. Add the citation with page number and one sentence of your own comment.

> **What to carry forward**
> Write from notes, not from the open page. Copying is a symptom of reading and writing at the same time.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Write an expository passage of about 200 words explaining how a student should evaluate an online source.

20 marks

1. Define the problem: anyone can publish, so authority must be checked.
2. Give a step sequence: author, date, evidence, purpose, corroboration.
3. Show one example of an unreliable source and why.
4. Close with a rule the reader can apply.
5. Check sentence boundaries and register.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Listing checks without explaining what each check reveals.

Q2. Distinguish summary, paraphrase and quotation, and state the citation obligation for each.

10 marks

1. Summary: whole argument, compressed, own words.
2. Paraphrase: specific passage, own words, close detail.
3. Quotation: exact words in quotation marks.
4. All three require citation; none replaces your own analysis.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Exposition. Writing that explains a subject in a sequence the reader can follow.

Claim. The proposition an argument asks the reader to accept.

Warrant. The principle that connects evidence to a claim.

Objection. The strongest reasonable case against a claim, which must be answered.

Paraphrase. Restating a specific passage in your own words and structure.

Summary. A compressed restatement of a source's whole argument.

Plagiarism. Presenting another person's words, structure or work as your own.

In-text citation. A brief reference in the body of the text pointing to a full source entry.

Corroboration. Supporting a claim by showing independent sources agree.

Register. The formality of language suited to a purpose and audience.

Thesis statement. The central claim of an essay, usually stated in the introduction.

Coherence. The logical connection of ideas across a whole piece of writing.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Exposition

Order and definition.

- Write a 200-word explanation of a process you know.
- Put the question in the first two sentences.
- Replace every vague example with a specific one.

Week 2 - Argument

Four parts.

- Label claim, warrant, evidence and objection in a published article.
- Write one paragraph with all four.
- Steel-man an objection to your own view.

Week 3 - Sources

Honest use.

- Summarise a source in three sentences from memory.
- Paraphrase a paragraph without copying structure.
- Build a citation list with page numbers.

Week 4 - Timed essay

Performance.

- Plan in five minutes, write in thirty-five.
- Check boundaries and citations.
- Compare against the marking guide.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any Use of English II text covering exposition, argument and citation.
- A study skills guide section on summarising and paraphrasing.
- Your faculty's citation and plagiarism policy.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Write a thesis for: 'Should first-year students be allowed to use AI tools for assignments?'

Answer: A defensible thesis: 'First-year students should be allowed to use AI tools for drafting and feedback, provided they disclose the use and remain responsible for the final argument.' It takes a position and sets a condition.

2. Which salutation pairs with 'Yours faithfully'?

Answer: 'Dear Sir/Madam' pairs with 'Yours faithfully'. 'Yours sincerely' pairs with a named recipient.

3. What is the difference between an expository and an argumentative essay?

Answer: An expository essay explains a topic clearly. An argumentative essay takes a position and defends it against objections.

4. Rewrite in formal register: 'I wanna ask if you guys can give me the job.'

Answer: 'I would like to apply for the position and would appreciate the opportunity to discuss my suitability.'

5. What belongs in the findings section of a report?

Answer: Observed facts, data and evidence gathered through the stated procedure, presented without recommendations. Recommendations belong in their own section.

6. Give three cohesive devices for showing contrast.

Answer: However, nevertheless, by contrast, whereas, on the other hand. Use one per paragraph rather than stacking them.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write one argumentative essay in 40 minutes using the five-minute plan.
- [ ] Write one formal application letter and check every layout element against the list in this pack.
- [ ] Convert a news article into a two-paragraph summary in your own words.
- [ ] Edit an old essay, marking every run-on sentence and pronoun ambiguity.
- [ ] Learn five new transition words and use each once in a paragraph.
- [ ] Write a one-page report on a campus problem with findings and recommendations.
- [ ] Ask a coursemate to identify your thesis from your introduction alone.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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